yes, kindliness abroad in the land that was inspiring to me as we all clung to the belief that, sooner or later, things would get better.

To make ends meet, my mother got a job as seamstress-clerk at a dress shop for $14 a week and Jack went on the road looking for work; at first they made a little extra income by subletting a portion of our house, but then things got so bad they couldn't even afford the rent on the house and they had to move to an apartment that was the upstairs of a onetime large home. When Moon and I came home, he slept on the couch and I slept on a cot on the upstairs landing.

I'll never forget one Christmas Eve during the Depression.

We'd never been able to afford a really fancy Christmas, but Jack and Nelle always managed to find a small gift for each other and one for Moon and me. When we couldn't afford a Christmas tree, Nelle found enough ribbon and crepe paper to decorate a table or make a cardboard fireplace out of a packing box to give our home a festive feeling. I'll never forget those Christmases when we didn't have much money but our home radiated with a love and warmth that meant a lot more to me than packages wrapped in colored paper.

On this particular Christmas Eve, Moon and I were getting ready to go out when a special delivery letter arrived for Jack. His eyes brightened. He'd recently gotten a job as a traveling shoe salesman—no salary, just commission—and thought the letter might contain a Christmas bonus.

We watched him pull out a sheet of paper from the envelope and waited to hear his good news. "Well, that's a hell of a Christmas present," he said bitterly. "I've been laid off."

After Moon and I returned to Eureka, my mother called me and asked if she could borrow $50. Jack hadn't been able to find work and she couldn't pay the grocery bill. I still had